could only be explained by a ‘conjunction of the two superior planets’, namely Saturn and Jupiter, which could be calculated only through a thorough understanding of astrology. Astrology at the time was a deeply respected science throughout the world. Up until the scientific revolution of the seventeenth century, it was treated on a par with history, grammar, and the sciences, and was an essential part of an elite education.

In 1398, Timur set his sights on the fabled city of Delhi and turned his fearsome cavalry towards the Khyber Pass. The sultans of Delhi had long protected the north-west mountain passes from the plunder of Chenghiz Khan’s armies, but by the fifteenth century, the might of the Tughlaqs of Delhi had shrunk considerably. Timur and the Tughlaq army clashed. Timur destroyed the Tughlaq army and plundered the city of Delhi, ‘massacring a reported 80,000 inhabitants and so thoroughly ruining the built landscape that it took the city nearly a century to recover’. For Timur never intended to remain in Delhi. He dreamed of building a glorious capital in Samarkand filled with Persianate art and architecture and he returned in 1399 to do exactly that with the booty and treasure he had plundered. Dreams for an empire in Hindustan would be for his descendant, Zahir al-din Muhammad, better known as Babur.

After Timur died in 1405, parts of his sprawling empire continued to be ruled for another 100 years by a succession of his descendants, while northern Hindustan, shattered by the effects of Timur’s plundering invasion, fragmented into a collection of independent provinces. According to historian Richard M. Eaton, this process had already begun before Timur’s invasion due to the slow collapse of the Delhi Sultanate and, by 1400, ‘the northern two-thirds of the subcontinent had become a patchwork quilt of independent kingdoms…’ It was at this moment that a talented and ambitious warrior of impeccable lineage looked towards the once lustrous capital of Delhi for consolation and glory.

Babur was a man who had a promising pedigree for a Central Asian warlord in the early sixteenth century. A descendant of Timur from his father’s side and a Chingizid from his mother’s, Babur’s was a destiny which was waiting to be forged. But this destiny would not unfurl itself in the storied city of Samarkand, or in his beloved homeland of Ferghana in Central Asia. These would be forever forfeit, to Babur’s abiding grief, to a tribe whose time had come— the Uzbeks. ‘For nearly 140 years the capital Samarkand had been in our family,’ wrote Babur bitterly in his memoir, the